musket fire assailed the walls of Kabul, Kamran had Akbar exposed upon the battlements – a child turned into a shield.

‘What . . . demon has such principles?’ cries Abul Fazl. It is not the anguished historian but Gulbadan – sister to both Kamran and Humayun – who offers the most measured account of this ignoble act. On the one hand, she suggests that Humayun was well aware of the need to calibrate his assault on Kamran to keep Akbar safe; that he even wrote, ‘if we had used force against the citadel, Mirza Muhammad Akbar would have disappeared’. His garrison, on the other hand, was losing patience – and no wonder, given the brutalities Kamran was inflicting on them. One day, one of the besiegers fired his gun at Kamran directly, at which the rattled prince decided to use his nephew as a deterrent. Meanwhile, she adds, Humayun’s men put Askari – Kamran’s blood brother – in the line of fire ‘and made fun of him’.

The historian Nizamuddin’s version is more dramatic. Not only did Kamran’s ‘dastardly feeling’ make him expose Akbar, he did so at exactly the spot where ‘balls and shot. . . fell thickest’. Seeing this, Maham Anaka, the mama who had once complained about Jiji Anaka monopolizing Akbar’s attentions, grabbed the child ‘in her bosom’ and held him safe from the fusillade.

Whatever the truth of Kamran’s offence (Jouher, for example, doesn’t mention it at all), and whatever the extent of Maham Anaka’s devotion (if the harem was locked away, how did she escape to the turrets?), the siege went in Humayun’s favour. In April 1547, a year or so after those glorious springtime celebrations to proclaim his rule, Humayun marched into Kabul a second time, was reunited with Akbar a second time, and mounted the throne[43] a second time.

The sense of déjà vu would continue: another year didn’t pass before Humayun was besieging his brother again.

Kamran had fled Kabul and gone northwards, hoping to form an alliance with Sulaiman of Badakhshan, whom Humayun had defeated in battle but reinstated when he came rushing back to Kabul. Kamran’s attempted alliance was unsuccessful.

Gulbadan tells a wonderful story that may be from this time, and explains Kamran’s failure. Sulaiman was married to a woman called Haram Begum;